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Awesome Mnemonics - Quick Reference Card

Print this page for your desk or on-call kit

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Crisis Response (Production Down)

STOP → TRACE → DEBUG → 8D

STOP (2-5 min)

- S - Step back
- T - Take a deep breath
- O - Observe what is happening
- P - Pull back and put things in perspective

TRACE (Network/System)

- T - Test connectivity
- R - Review logs and metrics
- A - Analyze packet captures
- C - Check configurations
- E - Escalate with documented evidence

DEBUG (Analysis)

- D - Define the problem
- E - Examine error messages/logs
- B - Break down into components
- U - Understand data flow
- G - Generate hypothesis and test

8D Approach (Resolution)

- D1 - Form a team
 - D2 - Describe the problem
 - D3 - Interim Containment Action
 - D4 - Root Cause Analysis (use 5 Whys)
 - D5 - Permanent Corrective Actions
 - D6 - Implement & Validate
 - D7 - Prevent reoccurrence
 - D8 - Congratulate your team and close the loop (closure & celebration)
-

Quick Decisions

IDEA → DICE → FATE (10-30 min)

IDEA

- I - Identify problem
- D - Develop Solution
- E - Execute Solution
- A - Assess Solution

DICE (Check Blockers)

- D - Delay
- I - Incompetence
- C - Conflict
- E - External factors

FATE (Resource Check)

- F - Funding
 - A - Allocation of resources
 - T - Time
 - E - Expertise
-

Conflict Resolution

WAIT → **BREATHE** → **PAUSE** → **RACI** (5-20 min)

WAIT

- “Why am I talking?” - Listen first

BREATHE

- B - Breathe deeply and slowly
- R - Remain rational and listen
- E - Empathize with the other person’s problem
- A - Ask questions to understand
- T - Take a break if needed
- H - Hold back from reacting
- E - Express yourself calmly

PAUSE

- P - Put things in perspective
- A - Acknowledge your feelings and theirs
- U - Understand you don’t have to react immediately
- S - Step Away from the situation
- E - Evaluate options and plan

RACI (Clarify Roles)

- R - Responsible (does the work)
 - A - Accountable (final approval)
 - C - Consulted (provides input)
 - I - Informed (kept updated)
-

Root Cause Analysis

ICEBERG → **5 Whys** → **PADDER** (1-2 hours)

ICEBERG

- I - Identify issue(s)
- C - Collect data and analyze situation
- E - Examine possible (root) causes
- B - Brainstorm solutions
- E - Execute solution(s)
- R - Review, evaluate, and adjust solutions
- G - Gather feedback

5 Whys

- Keep asking “Why?” until root cause identified
- Usually 3-5 iterations

Ishikawa (Fishbone)

- State problem (head); choose categories (e.g. 6 M's); brainstorm causes (bones); use 5 Whys on branches

A3 Problem Solving

- One-page: Background, Current state, Goal, Root cause (5 Whys/Ishikawa), Countermeasures, Plan

PADDER

- P - Pinpoint problem
 - A - Analyze data and look for patterns
 - D - Develop solution & consider other ways—try to have more than one option
 - D - Design action plan
 - E - Execute action plan & Monitor Results
 - R - Reevaluate and refine plan as needed
-

Stress Management

PACE → **ARIES** → **CALM** (10-15 min immediate, 2-4 weeks long-term)

PACE (Immediate)

- P - Physical activity
- A - Avoiding unhealthy behaviors
- C - Coping skills
- E - Emotional awareness

ARIES (Lifestyle)

- A - Avoid unnecessary stress
- R - Relax and take breaks
- I - Incorporate physical activity
- E - Eat a healthy diet
- S - Sleep well

CALM (Mental Framework)

- C - Confidence: Believe in your abilities
 - A - Awareness: Stay conscious of thoughts/feelings
 - L - Logic: Use rational thinking
 - M - Mindfulness: Practice being present
-

Infrastructure Design

SCALE → SWOT → PESTEL → SET

SCALE

- S - Security by design
- C - Capacity planning
- A - Automation-first
- L - Load balancing
- E - Error handling/resilience

SWOT (Evaluate Design)

- S - Strengths
- W - Weaknesses
- O - Opportunities
- T - Threats

PESTEL (External Factors)

- P - Political
- E - Economic
- S - Sociocultural
- T - Technological
- E - Environmental
- L - Legal

SET Triangle (Pick 2)

- Good / Fast / Cheap

- The third is what you won't get

Quick Situation Guide

(If icons don't display in your viewer: =crisis, =root cause, =conflict, =planning, =design, =debug, =stress. Row text is sufficient.)

Situation	Use This	Time
Immediate crisis	IDEA → STOP	2-5 min
Root cause needed	ICEBERG + 5 Whys	30-60 min
Team conflict	BREATHE → PAUSE → WAIT	5-10 min
Strategic planning	PREPARE + SWOT	1-2 hours
System design	SCALE + PESTEL	Planning phase
Technical debugging	TRACE → DEBUG	Variable
Stress overload	PACE → ARIES → CALM	10-15 min

Network Troubleshooting

TRACE

- T - Test connectivity (ping, traceroute)
 - R - Review logs and metrics
 - A - Analyze packet captures
 - C - Check configurations
 - E - Escalate with documented evidence
-

Key Principles

1. **Don't skip steps** - Each mnemonic builds on the previous one
 2. **Document at each stage** - Your insights inform the next step
 3. **Know when to branch** - If simple becomes complex, escalate
 4. **Always start with STOP** if emotionally activated
 5. **Use RACI** to clarify roles and prevent confusion
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Full guide: <https://github.com/StewAlexander-com/Awesome-Mnemonics>

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